

BRADFORD STARKE, INC.

CAPTURE MANAGEMENT STRATEGY GUIDE

A Senior Consultant's Field Manual for Winning Federal Contracts

From Pipeline to Award — The Complete Strategic Playbook

Mentored by the Federal Consulting Practice

Bradford Starke, Inc. | Strategy & Growth Division

Version 1.0 | 2025 | Proprietary & Confidential

Important Notice

This guide is produced by Bradford Starke, Inc. (BSI) for internal training and professional development purposes. All frameworks, processes, and strategic recommendations reflect BSI's consulting methodology based on publicly available federal acquisition regulations and industry best practices. This document does not constitute legal advice. Readers should consult qualified legal counsel before making binding business decisions.

How to Use This Guide

You are holding a field manual, not a textbook. Every chapter opens with a BLUF — a two-sentence summary of the bottom line. Read that first. If the concept matters to your current deal, read the full chapter. If not, bookmark it and move on. The federal marketplace rewards speed and precision. Train accordingly.

© 2025 Bradford Starke, Inc.. All rights reserved.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Chapter 1	The Federal Marketplace: Understanding the Battlefield	6
Chapter 2	Capture Management Fundamentals: The Strategic Framework	9
Chapter 3	Pipeline Development: Building Your Opportunity Engine	13
Chapter 4	Intelligence Gathering: Know the Customer Before They Know You	17
Chapter 5	Competitive Analysis: Positioning to Win	21
Chapter 6	Bid / No-Bid Decision Framework: Protecting Your Resources	25
Chapter 7	Teaming Strategy: Building the Winning Coalition	29
Chapter 8	Proposal Strategy: From Capture to Compliant Response	33
Chapter 9	Price-to-Win Analysis: The Science of the Right Number	37
Chapter 10	Post-Award & Lessons Learned: Turning Data into the Next Win	41

CHAPTER 1

The Federal Marketplace: Understanding the Battlefield

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

The U.S. federal government is the single largest buyer of goods and services on the planet, spending over \$700 billion annually — and every dollar of that is governed by a rule set your competitors are already studying. Understanding how this market works is not optional; it is your first competitive advantage.

The Strategic Partnership Analogy

Think of every federal agency as a major corporate client you are trying to win as a long-term partner. The government does not just need a vendor — it needs a trusted partner who understands its mission, speaks its language, and can deliver results under strict performance standards. Your job as a capture manager is to build that relationship long before a contract is ever posted publicly.

Scale of the Market

The numbers are staggering. The federal government awards contracts across every imaginable industry — from cybersecurity and cloud computing to facilities management and training services. The General Services Administration (GSA) alone manages billions in annual contract spend. Defense agencies, civilian agencies, and intelligence community buyers each operate with unique rules, cultures, and priorities.

This scale means opportunity is everywhere. But it also means competition is fierce and preparation is everything.

Key Market Segments

Segment	Primary Buyers	Typical Contract Size	Key Characteristic
Defense & National Security	DoD, Army, Navy, Air Force, DARPA	\$10M – \$5B+	Mission-critical, high compliance burden
Civilian Federal	DHS, HHS, DOT, DOE, Treasury	\$1M – \$500M	Policy-driven, stakeholder-heavy
Intelligence Community	NSA, CIA, NRO, DIA	\$5M – \$1B+	Clearance required, limited competition

Segment	Primary Buyers	Typical Contract Size	Key Characteristic
State & Local (SLED)	State agencies, municipalities	\$500K – \$50M	Faster cycle, less regulation
Quasi-Government	USPS, Amtrak, TVA	\$1M – \$200M	Hybrid commercial/federal rules

The Rule Book: Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR)

Every purchase the federal government makes — regardless of agency, size, or type — runs through the Master Rulebook known as the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR). This is a living document of over 2,000 pages that governs how agencies buy things, how contractors must behave, and what rights both parties have in the relationship.

You do not need to memorize the FAR. You need to know it exists, respect its power, and know where to look when something matters.

Critical FAR Concepts Every Business Developer Must Know

- **Part 6 — Competition Requirements:** Agencies must compete contracts unless a specific exception applies. Know those exceptions — they are your pathway to sole-source work.
- **Part 9 — Contractor Qualifications:** This governs who can bid. Past performance, financial stability, and key personnel all matter here.
- **Part 12 — Commercial Items:** Simplified acquisition pathway for commercial products and services. Easier to compete, faster to award.
- **Part 15 — Negotiated Acquisitions:** The most common path for large contracts. Proposals, discussions, and best-value awards all fall here.
- **Part 19 — Small Business:** Set-asides, certifications, and the rules that can give your firm access to protected competition.

Agency-Specific Supplements

Beyond the FAR, most major agencies add their own overlay of rules — called supplements. The Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement (DFARS) governs all DoD buys. The Health and Human Services Acquisition Regulation (HHSAR) covers HHS. These supplements layer additional requirements on top of the FAR. A seasoned capture manager reads both.

The Procurement Lifecycle: A High-Level View

Every federal contract award follows a predictable lifecycle. Your ability to influence the outcome diminishes dramatically at each stage. The best capture managers are engaged at Stage 1 — years before a contract is ever posted. Companies that show up at Stage 4 are usually writing checks they will never cash.

Stage	Phase Name	What Happens	Your Influence Level
1	Pre-Award Planning	Agency identifies a need, develops requirements, funds the effort	MAXIMUM — Shape the requirement
2	Market Research	Agency scans the market, talks to vendors, issues Requests for Information (RFIs)	HIGH — Position your firm as the expert
3	Solicitation	Agency publishes the Request for Proposal (RFP) or Request for Quote (RFQ)	MEDIUM — Respond with questions, influence amendments
4	Proposal Evaluation	Agency scores proposals against evaluation criteria	LOW — Your proposal is already submitted
5	Award & Protest Period	Contract is awarded; competitors may protest	MINIMAL — Legal strategy only
6	Contract Performance	Work begins; relationship and past performance are built	HIGH — Sets up the recompetes win

Why This Market Rewards Preparation

The companies that consistently win federal contracts are not always the biggest or the cheapest. They are the most prepared. They know the customer's pain before the customer writes it down. They have shaped the requirement to favor their solution. They have built relationships with the decision-makers who score proposals. That preparation has a name.

It is called capture management.

Pro-Tip: Study the agency's annual Strategic Plan and Budget Justification documents before you call on any program office — walking in with knowledge of their funded priorities signals you are a strategic partner, not a vendor looking for a handout.

Contract Vehicles: The On-Ramps to Federal Revenue

Not every federal purchase goes through a full, open competition. Many agencies buy through pre-established contract vehicles — think of these as pre-approved supplier lists where the government has already vetted your firm's qualifications and rates. Getting on the right vehicles before a requirement appears is one of the most powerful positioning moves in federal BD.

Vehicle Type	Examples	How It Works	Strategic Implication
Governmentwide Acquisition Contract (GWAC)	GSA STARS III, CIO-SP3, Alliant 2	Multiple-award vehicles; agencies issue task orders to contract holders	Must be on-contract to compete for task orders — get on early
Multiple Award Schedule (MAS)	GSA Schedule (formerly FSS)	Pre-negotiated commercial rates; simplified ordering process	Low barrier to entry; commoditizes pricing if not managed well
Blanket Purchase Agreement (BPA)	Agency-specific BPAs under GSA Schedules	Agency establishes preferred supplier list; frequent recurring orders	Relationship-dependent; excellent revenue predictability once established
Indefinite Delivery / Indefinite Quantity (IDIQ)	Agency-specific IDIQs, DoD IDIQs	Contract vehicle established; task orders issued against it	Winning a seat on an IDIQ is its own capture campaign — treat it that way
Other Transaction Authority (OTA)	DHS, DoD OTA consortia	Bypasses FAR for prototyping and rapid acquisition	Fastest path to DoD for non-traditional contractors and innovators

Fiscal Year Dynamics: Timing Is Strategy

The federal government operates on a fiscal year running from October 1 through September 30. This calendar shapes everything — when budgets are released, when awards cluster, and when agencies are most receptive to new relationships. Understand it and plan around it.

- **October through December:** New fiscal year begins. New money arrives. Agencies award contracts that were delayed at year-end. High activity window for new awards.
- **January through March:** Mid-year reviews. Agencies assess spend rates. A good time for capability briefings and strategic conversations.
- **April through June:** RFP activity surges. Agencies push to award before fiscal year end. Proposal season intensifies.
- **July through September:** Year-end spending sprint. Agencies obligate remaining funds. Expect a flood of awards, modifications, and task orders. Be ready.

The Continuing Resolution (CR) trap is real. When Congress fails to pass an appropriations bill by October 1, agencies operate under a CR — which typically limits new contract starts and restricts spending to prior-year levels. If your target award falls during a CR period, expect delays of 3 to 6 months and plan accordingly.

CHAPTER 2

Capture Management Fundamentals: The Strategic Framework

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

Capture management is the disciplined, intelligence-driven process of winning a specific federal contract before the solicitation is ever published. Done right, it is the difference between a 20% win rate and an 80% win rate — and that gap goes directly to your firm's top line.

What Capture Management Actually Is

Here is the truth most companies learn too late: if you are writing a proposal without first running a capture campaign, you are not competing — you are donating. Proposal writing is the last 10% of the work. The first 90% happens in the field, in program offices, in industry days, and in competitive intelligence sessions.

Capture management is the systematic effort to understand a specific opportunity so thoroughly that your proposal writes itself. Every customer conversation, every competitor assessment, every pricing model feeds into a strategy that aligns your solution to the customer's stated and unstated needs better than anyone else can.

The Capture Manager Role

The Capture Manager (CM) is your deal's quarterback. This person owns the win strategy from the moment your firm identifies an opportunity worth pursuing. The CM is not a proposal writer — though they must understand proposals deeply. The CM is a strategist, a relationship builder, a competitive analyst, and a resource allocator all in one.

Core Responsibilities of the Capture Manager

- **Opportunity Ownership:** Single point of accountability for the deal from identification to award.
- **Customer Engagement:** Building and deepening relationships with the decision-making unit inside the target agency.
- **Intelligence Collection:** Gathering and synthesizing competitive, customer, and market intelligence.
- **Win Strategy Development:** Crafting the overarching narrative and differentiators that drive the proposal.
- **Team Assembly:** Identifying and securing the right internal resources, partners, and subcontractors.
- **Gate Reviews:** Leading the firm through internal bid/no-bid and strategy checkpoints.

- **Proposal Transition:** Handing off a fully-baked strategy to the proposal team with zero ambiguity.

The Capture Lifecycle Timeline

Effective capture is a timed operation. The earlier you engage, the more you can shape. Most mature capture programs operate on an 18 to 36 month horizon for large contracts. Missing these windows is not just bad strategy — it is throwing money away on proposals you cannot win.

Timeline	Milestone	Key Capture Activities
36–24 Months Out	Opportunity Identification	Add to pipeline; assign capture lead; begin customer mapping; attend industry days
24–12 Months Out	Active Capture Phase	Customer meetings; competitive assessment; solution development; teaming discussions
12–6 Months Out	Pre-RFP Preparation	Influence requirements via RFI responses; finalize team; develop win themes; price modeling
6–3 Months Out	Proposal Readiness	Mock proposal drafts; color team reviews; price-to-win analysis; BAFO preparation
RFP Release	Proposal Execution	Formal proposal kickoff; assign writers; comply with instructions; submit on time
Post-Submission	Competitive Phase	Oral presentations; clarifications; Final Proposal Revision (FPR); monitor for award

The Three Laws of Capture

Every winning capture campaign is built on three non-negotiable principles. Violate any one of them and you will lose deals that should have been yours.

Law 1: Customer First, Solution Second

You do not start with your capability. You start with the customer's problem. Too many companies lead with 'here is what we do' instead of 'here is what keeps you up at night.' The customer does not care what you have sold before. They care whether you understand their mission and can make their life easier. Understand the mission first. Then align your solution to it.

Law 2: Intelligence Drives Strategy

A win strategy built on assumptions is not a strategy — it is a guess. Capture managers who win consistently build their strategies on verified customer intelligence, competitive data, and pricing analysis. They know who the incumbent is, what the incumbent charges, where the incumbent has failed, and exactly how to exploit that gap.

Law 3: Early In, Often Better

The earlier you enter a pursuit, the more you can shape it. Every month you wait to engage a customer, a competitor is already in the room. Relationships are built over time, not in a single meeting. Solutions that match the customer's language tend to come from firms who were involved in conversations before the requirement was ever written. Start early. Stay consistent.

Capture Maturity Model

BSI evaluates its clients' capture capability using a five-level maturity model. Be honest about where your firm sits today. Most firms that lose more than 40% of competitive bids are operating at Level 1 or Level 2.

Level	Maturity Name	Characteristic Behaviors	Typical Win Rate
1	Reactive	Responds to RFPs with no prior engagement; no pipeline; ad hoc proposals	10–20%
2	Developing	Tracks opportunities; occasional customer contact; inconsistent strategy	20–35%
3	Defined	Formal capture process; regular pipeline reviews; some pre-RFP shaping	35–50%
4	Managed	Data-driven intelligence; disciplined gate reviews; PTW analysis standard	50–65%
5	Optimized	Continuous improvement; predictive pipeline; customer co-development	65–80%+

Pro-Tip: Assign every active pursuit a Capture Maturity score at kickoff — it forces your team to face the reality of their intelligence gaps and builds a prioritized action plan before a single proposal page is ever written.

CHAPTER 3

Pipeline Development: Building Your Opportunity Engine

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

A healthy business development pipeline is the most honest predictor of future revenue — a weak pipeline means next year's numbers are already bad, whether you know it yet or not. Build it with discipline, manage it with data, and never let it run dry.

What a Pipeline Actually Is

Your pipeline is a living inventory of every federal opportunity your firm is tracking, pursuing, or positioned to win. It is not a wish list. It is not a database of every contract on SAM.gov. A real pipeline is a curated, qualified, prioritized set of pursuits where you have a credible path to winning based on customer access, competitive positioning, and solution fit.

Most firms that struggle with revenue predictability do not have a pipeline problem — they have a discipline problem. They confuse activity with progress and volume with quality.

Pipeline Stages

Every opportunity in your pipeline should be assigned to one of five stages. Stage assignment is not a formality — it drives resource allocation, gate review scheduling, and revenue forecasting accuracy.

Stage	Stage Name	Definition	Probability Weight
1 — Identified	Opportunity Identified	RFP anticipated; minimal or no customer contact; added to watchlist	5–10%
2 — Qualifying	Active Qualification	Customer engaged; initial intel gathered; bid/no-bid decision pending	15–25%
3 — Pursuing	Committed Pursuit	Bid/no-bid approved; capture plan active; customer meetings ongoing	30–50%
4 — Proposing	Proposal in Development	RFP received; proposal team engaged; final strategy locked	50–70%
5 — Submitted	Awaiting Award	Proposal submitted; pending evaluation and award decision	70–90%

Pipeline Coverage Ratio: The Most Important Number You May Not Be Tracking

The Pipeline Coverage Ratio is the total value of your qualified pipeline divided by your annual revenue target. Think of it as how much raw opportunity you need to convert a dollar. Most federal contractors need a 3x to 5x coverage ratio to hit their annual number with confidence.

If your revenue target is \$10 million, you need a pipeline carrying \$30–50 million in qualified, stage-appropriate opportunities. That is not padding — that is the math of realistic win rates and deal slippage.

Where Opportunities Come From

Primary Intelligence Sources

- **SAM.gov (System for Award Management):** The federal government's official contracting platform. Every solicitation above the micro-purchase threshold must be posted here. Your team should have daily alerts configured.
- **USASpending.gov:** Shows you what has already been awarded, to whom, for how much, and under which vehicle. Use this to find expiring contracts and incumbent weak spots.
- **GovWin IQ and Deltek:** Subscription-based opportunity intelligence platforms. Paid but worth every dollar — they aggregate pre-solicitation intelligence that SAM.gov does not carry.
- **Agency Budget Justifications:** Published annually to Congress. They tell you exactly what the agency plans to buy before a single solicitation is posted.
- **Industry Days and Pre-Solicitation Conferences:** Face-to-face moments with contracting officers and program managers. Show up. Be prepared. Be visible.
- **Incumbent Contract Watch:** Any contract expiring within 18 months is a live opportunity. Find them on USASpending.gov and engage immediately.

Pipeline Hygiene: The Non-Negotiable Discipline

A pipeline full of stale, unqualified, or wishful opportunities is worse than no pipeline — it gives leadership false confidence and misdirects resources. Enforce these hygiene rules ruthlessly:

- **Weekly Stage Review:** Every pursuit at Stage 3 or above should be reviewed weekly for status changes, customer developments, and resource needs.
- **Monthly Full-Pipeline Scrub:** Remove opportunities that have slipped more than 90 days without progress. Move them to a watch list — they are not pipeline.
- **Quarterly Win Strategy Review:** Every Stage 3+ opportunity should have a documented win strategy. If you cannot articulate why you will win, you are not pursuing — you are hoping.
- **Annual Portfolio Review:** Assess which markets, agencies, and contract vehicles generated the best returns. Double down on winners. Cut losers.

Building a Balanced Portfolio

A healthy pipeline is not just big — it is balanced. You need opportunities across different time horizons, agencies, and contract values to smooth out the inevitable volatility of federal contracting. Build for three horizons simultaneously:

Horizon 1 — Harvest (0–12 Months)

These are your near-term revenue sources — recompetes on contracts you already hold, follow-on task orders, and contract modifications. Protect them fiercely. A recompile loss hurts more than a new business loss because you are replacing revenue you already had.

Horizon 2 — Build (12–24 Months)

These are active pursuits where you have completed at least 60% of your capture campaign. The customer knows you. Your strategy is clear. This is where most of your BD investment should sit.

Horizon 3 — Seed (24–36+ Months)

These are early-stage opportunities where you are planting relationship seeds and shaping requirements. Low investment now, high return later. Every company needs a Horizon 3 bench to ensure two years from now there is still a Horizon 1.

Pro-Tip: Run a quarterly 'dead deal autopsy' — formally document why you lost every Horizon 2 opportunity that did not convert, and use that data to fix your Horizon 3 strategy before it is too late.

CHAPTER 4

Intelligence Gathering: Know the Customer Before They Know You

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

The single most powerful differentiator between companies that win federal contracts and companies that lose them is the depth of their customer intelligence — not their technical capabilities, not their price, and certainly not their proposal writing skills.

The Intelligence Imperative

You cannot solve a problem you do not understand. And you cannot understand a federal customer's problem by reading the RFP — by the time the RFP is published, the requirements are locked. The window to shape the outcome is the 18 to 24 months before that document appears. That window is yours to own, if you use it.

Customer intelligence is not corporate espionage. It is disciplined listening, strategic questioning, and systematic synthesis of publicly available information combined with direct relationship building. It is entirely legal, deeply ethical, and devastatingly effective when done right.

The Customer Intelligence Framework

BSI's capture methodology organizes customer intelligence into four categories. Every one of these should be addressed before your firm commits resources to a pursuit.

Category 1: Mission Intelligence

What is the agency trying to achieve? What are its strategic goals, performance metrics, and congressional mandates? Understanding the mission lets you frame your solution in language the customer already uses internally — which signals you are a partner who gets it, not a vendor who just wants the work.

- Review the agency's Strategic Plan (published on agency websites and OMB)
- Study the Congressional Budget Justification (CBJ) for funded priorities
- Monitor agency press releases, leadership speeches, and Inspector General (IG) reports
- Track Government Accountability Office (GAO) recommendations relevant to the agency

Category 2: Requirements Intelligence

What does the customer actually need — and what do they think they need? These two things are often different. A seasoned capture manager finds the gap between stated requirements and actual mission need, then builds a solution that bridges both.

- Engage program office staff in direct conversations — ask about pain points, not requirements
- Review predecessor contracts and their performance work statements
- Study prior RFPs, amendments, and Q&A; responses from previous competitions
- Respond thoughtfully to every Request for Information (RFI) — it gets you in the room

Category 3: Decision Intelligence

Who are the people making the award decision? Federal contracting involves multiple stakeholders — program managers, contracting officers, technical evaluators, and senior leadership. You need a relationship with each layer of that decision-making unit.

Role	Title	Primary Interest	How to Engage
End User / Program Manager	Program Manager (PM)	Mission success, performance, relationship	Technical conversations, solutions demos, mission alignment
Technical Evaluator	Technical Lead / SME	Technical soundness, innovation, team qualifications	White papers, technical exchanges, industry day questions
Contracting Authority	Contracting Officer (CO)	Compliance, competition, FAR adherence	Formal channels only; no inappropriate contact
Financial Authority	Budget Officer / CFO	Value for money, cost control, risk mitigation	ROI data, benchmarks, cost efficiency narratives
Senior Leadership	Agency Head / Deputy	Strategic alignment, mission outcomes, risk	Executive briefings, strategic partnership conversations

Category 4: Budget Intelligence

No money, no contract. Understanding the agency's budget situation — specifically whether the requirement is funded, at what level, and in which fiscal year — is not optional. More pursuits die from budget uncertainty than from competition.

- Track the President's Budget Request (PBR) and Congressional Appropriations for target agencies
- Monitor Continuing Resolution (CR) periods — they delay awards and shrink available funds
- Study prior-year obligation rates for the program office you are targeting
- Ask directly in conversations: 'Is this requirement funded in the current fiscal year?'

Primary vs. Secondary Intelligence

Intelligence comes from two sources. Both matter. Neither alone is sufficient.

Primary Intelligence — Earned by Showing Up

This is intelligence you gather firsthand — through customer meetings, industry days, conference conversations, site visits, and direct program office engagement. It is the highest-quality intelligence you can have, and it is also the hardest to get. It requires persistence, credibility, and the ability to ask the right questions without burning a relationship.

Secondary Intelligence — Mined from Public Sources

This is intelligence derived from publicly available documents, procurement databases, and market research tools. It is faster to gather but requires more synthesis. The goal is to use secondary intelligence to prepare for primary intelligence conversations — walk into every customer meeting having already done your homework.

The RFI: Your Intelligence-Gathering Superweapon

When an agency publishes a Request for Information (RFI), most companies treat it as optional — background noise on their way to the real competition. That is a strategic mistake. The RFI is your clearest window into the customer's thinking before requirements are locked.

- **Always respond to RFIs for opportunities you are pursuing.** Absence from the response set signals to the customer you either do not know about the requirement or do not care enough to engage.
- **Use your RFI response to shape the requirement.** Propose evaluation criteria, contract structures, and performance standards that favor your solution.
- **Include a call to action.** Offer a briefing, a demo, a white paper. Give the customer a reason to pick up the phone and call you.
- **Analyze the full response set.** When agency posts a summary of industry inputs, read every comment. It reveals your competitors' positioning and the customer's emerging priorities.

Pro-Tip: Establish a 'Customer Contact Log' for every active pursuit — document every interaction, what was said, who was in the room, and what intelligence was gathered; over an 18-month capture cycle, this log becomes a strategic goldmine worth more than any market research report you can buy.

CHAPTER 5

Competitive Analysis: Positioning to Win

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

You do not win federal contracts by being good — you win by being better than the specific competitors the customer is evaluating you against. Competitive analysis is the strategic discipline that tells you exactly where those gaps are and how to exploit them.

Why Competitive Analysis Is Non-Negotiable

Every federal procurement is a relative competition. The evaluators are not asking 'Is this proposal good?' They are asking 'Is this proposal better than the others?' If you are not investing in understanding your competition, you are submitting into a void — hoping your proposal lands above a bar you have never measured.

Competitive intelligence is not gossip. It is a structured, ethical process of gathering publicly available information, synthesizing it into strategic insights, and using those insights to make your proposal sharper, your price smarter, and your team stronger.

Identifying the Competitive Landscape

Start with the incumbent. Then work outward. For any major federal opportunity, you can reconstruct the likely competitive field using publicly available data before the RFP is ever issued.

Step 1: Identify the Incumbent

Go to USASpending.gov and find the current contract. Who holds it? How long have they held it? What do they charge? What is their staffing model? The incumbent has the single greatest advantage in any recompetes — they have existing customer relationships, trained staff, and institutional knowledge. Your strategy must directly address how you overcome that advantage.

Step 2: Identify Likely Challengers

Who else attends the agency's industry days for this program? Who has responded to prior RFIs? Who holds similar contracts at comparable agencies? Build a list of three to five likely competitors and start profiling each one.

Step 3: Profile Each Competitor

Intelligence Category	What to Research	Where to Find It
Past Performance	Contract wins, losses, agency feedback, performance ratings	USASpending.gov, CPARS (if available through customer), news
Pricing Strategy	Historical bid prices, contract modifications, ceiling rates	USASpending.gov, FOIA requests, contract databases
Key Personnel	Who leads their capture teams, named personnel on comparable contracts	LinkedIn, company bios, prior proposal rosters (public procurements)
Teaming Patterns	Who they typically partner with, exclusivity arrangements	SAM.gov teaming notifications, press releases, SEC filings
Technical Approach	Prior proposals (where public), white papers, conference presentations	Agency FOIA libraries, company websites, conference proceedings
Financial Health	Revenue trends, profit margins, M&A; activity	Annual reports, Dun & Bradstreet, Bloomberg, SEC EDGAR

The Competitor SWOT: Do It For Everyone

For every major pursuit, run a formal Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats (SWOT) analysis on each key competitor — and then run one on yourself. The purpose is not to feel good about your firm. It is to find the exploitable gaps where your solution is objectively stronger than what competitors will offer.

The Ghost Proposal Exercise

This is one of BSI's most powerful capture tools. Before writing a single word of your proposal, write the ghost proposal — the proposal you believe the incumbent will submit. Articulate their strengths, their key themes, their likely price, and their probable weaknesses. Then build your proposal to specifically and systematically outperform it.

Every discriminator you write, every win theme you develop, every price decision you make should be tested against one question: 'Does this beat the ghost proposal?' If the answer is yes, keep it. If the answer is maybe, sharpen it. If the answer is no, fix it.

Competitive Positioning Matrix

Once you have profiled the field, build a positioning matrix. This tool maps your firm and your competitors against the evaluation criteria the customer is most likely to use. It makes your competitive gaps visible and forces a clear conversation about whether your win strategy actually addresses them.

Evaluation Factor	Your Firm	Incumbent	Challenger A	Challenger B	Your Advantage
Technical Approach	Strong	Strong	Moderate	Weak	Differentiate on innovation
Past Performance	Strong	Very Strong	Strong	Moderate	Volume matters less than recency
Key Personnel	Strong	Strong	Moderate	Moderate	Exclusive hires are your edge
Management Plan	Strong	Moderate	Moderate	Strong	Highlight transition plan
Price / Cost	Competitive	Higher (known)	Unknown	Lower (risk)	PTW analysis required

Developing True Discriminators

A discriminator is not a feature. It is a provable, meaningful difference between your solution and your competitors' solutions that directly addresses a customer pain point. Discriminators are not bragging rights. They are weapons.

- **True Discriminator:** 'Our proprietary workflow automation tool reduced processing time by 47% on a comparable DoD contract — validated in a publicly available performance report.'
- **False Discriminator:** 'We are committed to excellence and deliver high-quality results.' (This is every company's tagline. It means nothing.)

The test for a true discriminator is simple. Ask: 'Can a competitor say the exact same thing about themselves?' If yes, it is not a discriminator. Go deeper. Find something no one else can honestly claim.

Pro-Tip: Buy the incumbent's last proposal from the agency's FOIA (Freedom of Information Act) library — many winning proposals from past competitions are publicly releasable, and reading one is worth more than ten competitor profiles built from secondary research alone.

CHAPTER 6

Bid / No-Bid Decision Framework: Protecting Your Resources

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

The most important word in business development is 'no' — saying no to the wrong opportunities protects the resources you need to say yes to the right ones. A disciplined bid/no-bid process is how mature firms stay profitable while others bleed out chasing every RFP they see.

Why Saying No Is a Power Move

Proposal development is expensive. A competitive federal proposal for a \$10 million contract can cost \$50,000 to \$150,000 in labor, materials, and management time — and that cost is 100% at risk until the award notice lands. Companies that bid on everything lose on most, burn their best people, and erode morale. Companies that bid with discipline win more, cost less, and build stronger teams.

The bid/no-bid decision is not administrative. It is a strategic capital allocation decision, and it deserves the same rigor as any investment decision your firm makes.

The BSI Bid/No-Bid Scoring Framework

Use the following 10-factor scoring model on every pursuit before committing to a full proposal effort. Score each factor from 1 to 5. A total score below 30 is a strong no-bid signal. A score between 30 and 38 requires a remediation plan. A score above 38 warrants full commitment.

Factor	What You Are Measuring	Score 1–5
Customer Relationship	Do we have direct access to the program office decision-makers?	___
Requirement Fit	Does this requirement align with our core capabilities and past performance?	___
Competitive Position	Can we honestly name three reasons we will win against the likely field?	___
Incumbent Status	Are we the incumbent, or do we have a credible strategy to unseat one?	___
Budget Confidence	Is the requirement funded, and is the customer committed to awarding?	___

Factor	What You Are Measuring	Score 1–5
Teaming Readiness	Do we have the right partners locked in or in active discussions?	—
Price Competitiveness	Can we price to win while maintaining acceptable margins?	—
Proposal Capacity	Do we have the internal bandwidth to write a competitive proposal?	—
Strategic Value	Does this win advance our long-term agency or capability strategy?	—
Schedule Viability	Is the proposal timeline achievable with current resources?	—

The Gate Review Process

The gate review is a formal, scheduled checkpoint where leadership evaluates a pursuit's health and authorizes continued investment. Think of it as a series of investment committee meetings — each one either approves more capital or cuts the loss. BSI recommends three mandatory gate reviews on all pursuits above \$5 million.

Gate 1 — Opportunity Qualification (18–24 Months Out)

Decision: Should we add this opportunity to our active pipeline and begin preliminary customer engagement? At this gate, you need a validated customer need, a plausible competitive position, and strategic alignment with your firm's growth plan. If you cannot answer yes to all three, the opportunity goes to a watch list, not the pipeline.

Gate 2 — Capture Commitment (6–12 Months Out)

Decision: Should we invest fully in a capture campaign and commit dedicated resources? By this gate, you should have direct customer access, a draft win strategy, an initial competitive assessment, and a teaming concept. This is where real money starts flowing. Make the decision with clear eyes.

Gate 3 — Proposal Authorization (RFP Release)

Decision: Should we write and submit a proposal? This is the last chance to walk away before the most expensive phase begins. Evaluate your current win probability, the updated competitive landscape, and any changes to the requirement since your capture work began. If the win probability has fallen below 30%, a no-bid is not a failure — it is fiscal discipline.

Common No-Bid Triggers

These are signals that almost always justify a no-bid decision, even on opportunities that initially looked attractive:

- The incumbent has held the contract for 10+ years with no reported performance issues
- You have never met the program manager and the RFP drops in fewer than 45 days
- A key competitor has already hired the agency's former contracting officer or program manager
- The agency has issued six amendments since the original RFP — the requirement is unstable
- Your proposed price to win yields a margin below your floor — the work will lose money
- You cannot staff the key personnel positions with people the customer will recognize and trust
- The evaluation criteria heavily favor an incumbent's specific, non-replicable past performance

Pro-Tip: When you no-bid an opportunity, send the agency a brief, professional letter explaining why — it shows strategic sophistication, keeps the relationship warm, and occasionally results in the agency modifying requirements to bring you back in.

CHAPTER 7

Teaming Strategy: Building the Winning Coalition

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

In federal contracting, the team you assemble before the RFP drops is often the difference between winning and losing — the right teaming partner fills a capability gap, unlocks a set-aside, adds mission-critical past performance, and can turn a 40% win probability into a 70% one overnight.

Why Teaming Matters

Federal contracts rarely go to a single company acting alone on large, complex requirements. The government wants to see a team that covers all the bases — the right technical capabilities, the right clearances, the right small business representation, and the right past performance across the full scope of work. Your teaming strategy is, in effect, your solution architecture.

Teaming is also a competitive weapon. Locking up the best subcontractors before your competitors can reach them is a legitimate and powerful capture tactic. Once a strong sub is committed to your team, they are off the market for everyone else.

Team Structure: Roles and Responsibilities

Prime Contractor

The prime holds the contract and is legally responsible for all performance. The prime controls the team, owns the customer relationship, and absorbs the performance risk. Being the prime is the highest-value position — and the highest-risk one.

Subcontractor

Subs provide specific capabilities the prime needs but may not possess internally. They operate under a subcontract agreement that flows down the prime contract's terms and conditions. Strong subs with agency-specific past performance can dramatically strengthen a proposal.

Mentor-Protégé Arrangement

Under the Small Business Administration (SBA) Mentor-Protégé Program, a large business can partner with a qualifying small business and jointly pursue contracts, with both firms' capabilities combined for evaluation purposes. This is one of the most powerful competitive vehicles in the federal market.

Small Business Teaming: The Set-Aside Advantage

The federal government sets aside over 25% of its total contract dollars for small businesses. If your firm holds a small business designation — or if you can build a team around one — you are competing in a protected pool with fewer, smaller competitors. Know every small business designation and which ones apply to your strategy.

Designation	Full Name	Eligibility	Strategic Value
8(a)	8(a) Business Development Program	Socially/economically disadvantaged small business	Sole-source awards up to \$4.5M (services), \$7.5M (manufacturing)
SDVOSB	Service-Disabled Veteran-Owned Small Business	51%+ owned/controlled by service-disabled veterans	Set-asides at VA and other agencies; strong goodwill
WOSB	Women-Owned Small Business	51%+ owned/controlled by women	WOSB and EDWOSB set-asides in underrepresented NAICS codes
HUBZone	Historically Underutilized Business Zone	Principal office in HUBZone; 35% HUBZone employees	Set-asides and price evaluation preferences (10%)
SB	Small Business (general)	Revenue/employee-based size standards by NAICS code	Access to small business set-aside pool — largest market

Teaming Agreement Essentials

A teaming agreement is a pre-proposal legal instrument that defines the relationship between your firm and a potential subcontractor. It is not a subcontract — it does not guarantee the sub any work. It is a mutual commitment to pursue the opportunity together and a framework for negotiating the actual subcontract if you win.

What a Teaming Agreement Must Address

- **Exclusivity Clause:** Will the sub work exclusively with your team on this opportunity, or can they team with competitors?
- **Work Share:** What percentage of the contract value does the sub expect to receive, and for which work?
- **Proposal Contributions:** What content, resumes, and past performance is the sub committing to provide?
- **Termination Rights:** Under what circumstances can either party exit the agreement without penalty?
- **Non-Disclosure:** Protecting proprietary information shared during the teaming process.

When Teaming Goes Wrong

Teaming is powerful. It is also a source of proposal failures and post-award disputes when managed poorly. These are the most common teaming traps:

- **The Hollow Sub:** A subcontractor who signs a teaming agreement, contributes nothing to the proposal, then demands a large work share after award. Tie sub work share to proposal contributions contractually.
- **The Competitor Sub:** A sub who is simultaneously teaming with your competitor on the same bid. Enforce exclusivity in your teaming agreement.
- **The Key Person Bait-and-Switch:** A sub who names a senior executive as a key person in the proposal, then replaces them with a junior employee after award. Name all key people and get them committed in writing.
- **Over-Teaming:** A team so large and diffuse that the work share per firm is too small to be meaningful. Keep your core team tight — three to five partners is usually optimal.

Pro-Tip: Lock up the three best subcontractors for your target opportunity at least 12 months before RFP release — by the time the solicitation drops, your competition will find the best players are already off the market, and that structural advantage compounds over the entire evaluation.

CHAPTER 8

Proposal Strategy: From Capture to Compliant Response

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

Your proposal is not a capabilities brochure — it is a legal argument for why your firm should be awarded this specific contract, structured to score maximum points against each evaluation criterion the government will use to rank you against your competitors.

The Proposal as the Culmination of Capture

By the time your proposal team sits down to write, the hard work should already be done. The win strategy is locked. The team is assembled. The customer's hot buttons are documented. The competitive differentiation is clear. A proposal written without that foundation is just expensive guessing.

Proposal writing, done right, is translation — taking everything your capture team has learned and translating it into a compelling, compliant, scored response that makes the evaluator's job easy.

Understanding How Proposals Are Evaluated

The federal government evaluates proposals using one of three frameworks, each of which requires a different proposal strategy:

Lowest Price Technically Acceptable (LPTA)

The award goes to the lowest-priced proposal that meets the minimum technical requirements. In an LPTA environment, differentiation above the technical floor adds no value. Your strategy is to be compliant and cheap — not excellent and expensive. Know when to stop adding features.

Best Value Tradeoff

The agency balances technical merit, past performance, and price in a structured tradeoff. A higher-priced proposal can win if its technical superiority is worth the premium. Your strategy is to build a clear, quantifiable argument for why your solution's additional cost generates better mission outcomes.

Highest Technically Rated At Fair and Reasonable Price (HTRAFFP)

The agency wants the highest technical score but is also constrained to pay a fair and reasonable price. This is increasingly common. Your strategy is to maximize technical differentiation while pricing at or below

the market midpoint.

The Color Review System

Every mature proposal operation uses a structured review system to catch compliance failures, sharpen win themes, and pressure-test the technical approach before submission. BSI recommends four formal reviews:

Review	Color Code	Timing	Purpose	Participants
Kickoff Review	White	RFP + 48 hours	Align team on strategy, assign volumes, confirm resources	Capture Manager, Volume Leads, BD Lead
Concept Review	Pink	25% draft complete	Validate compliance, test win themes, align sections	Capture Manager, Red Team Lead, Subject Experts
Draft Review	Red	75% draft complete	Full compliance check, evaluate against scoring criteria, refine discriminators	External evaluators, Senior Leadership
Final Review	Gold	95% complete	Production quality check, final pricing validation, submission readiness	PM, Contracts, Production Team

Win Theme Development

Every proposal volume should open with and return to three to five core win themes — the strategic narrative that connects your solution to the customer's mission and differentiates you from the competition. Win themes are not bullet points. They are arguments.

The Win Theme Formula

A powerful win theme has four components: the customer's need, your discriminating solution, the measurable benefit, and the substantiating evidence. Arranged together, they form a sentence the evaluator wants to believe before you have even proven it.

- **Need:** 'The Agency requires a seamless transition to prevent mission disruption during contract changeover.'
- **Solution:** 'Our 90-day parallel operations transition model has been executed on seven comparable programs.'
- **Benefit:** 'This approach has resulted in zero mission gaps and an average 12% performance improvement in the first 60 days.'
- **Evidence:** 'Validated in our CPARS rating on Contract #HHSN123456 and cited in our reference letters.'

Compliance vs. Responsiveness

Many proposals are eliminated before they are ever scored — because they are non-compliant. Non-compliance means the proposal failed to follow the instructions in the RFP. Missing a page limit. Omitting a required section. Wrong font size. These are not minor errors. They are disqualifying failures.

Compliance is the floor. Every word in Section L (Instructions to Offerors) and Section M (Evaluation Factors) of the RFP is a directive. Build a compliance matrix on Day 1 and check every requirement before submission.

- **Section L compliance:** Did we follow every formatting, content, and submission instruction?
- **Section M responsiveness:** Does our proposal directly address every evaluation factor at the level of detail required to earn maximum scores?

Pro-Tip: *On the day the RFP drops, read Section M first — the evaluation factors are the scoring rubric, and every word you write in the proposal should be written to score maximum points on those factors, not to describe your company in general terms.*

CHAPTER 9

Price-to-Win Analysis: The Science of the Right Number

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

Price-to-Win (PTW) analysis is the process of estimating the highest price you can charge while still winning — it is not about pricing low, it is about pricing smart, and the firms that master it consistently outperform their competitors on profitability without sacrificing win rate.

Why Price Matters More Than You Think

Price kills more proposals than weak technical approaches. But overpricing kills more quietly than underpricing — you never know you lost because of price until after the award notice. Price-to-Win analysis removes the guesswork. It replaces intuition with a data-driven target built from competitive intelligence, historical awards, and labor market data.

This is not about submitting the lowest number. It is about understanding the competitive pricing band and positioning yourself strategically within it.

The PTW Analysis Framework

Step 1: Define the Competitive Pricing Band

Based on your competitive intelligence, estimate each key competitor's likely price range. This requires knowledge of their labor rates, overhead structures, teaming arrangements, and historical pricing patterns. The resulting range — from the likely floor (most aggressive price) to the ceiling (highest competitive price) — is your battleground.

Step 2: Estimate the Incumbent's Price

The incumbent's price is the most important data point in your PTW analysis. They have built-in efficiencies, sunk transition costs, and often price conservatively to protect an existing relationship. You need to know their current contract value, their staffing levels, and their known overhead rates to model their likely recompile price.

Step 3: Model Your Own Cost

Build a bottom-up cost estimate for your proposed approach. Use your own direct labor rates, wrap rates, subcontractor pricing, and material costs. This is your cost basis — the number below which you lose

money. The gap between your cost basis and the PTW target is your margin. Protect it.

Step 4: Identify Price-Performance Tradeoffs

For best-value competitions, the question is never 'What is the lowest price we can submit?' It is 'What price maximizes our expected value score — where expected value equals our probability of winning multiplied by our expected profit?' Sometimes a higher price with a stronger technical approach yields more expected value than a low price with a weaker one.

Key Pricing Inputs

Input Category	Data Source	How It Affects PTW
Incumbent Contract Value	USASpending.gov, FOIA	Sets the recompetite pricing anchor — most competitors will price near this level
Labor Market Rates	Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS), salary surveys, GSA schedule rates	Determines whether you can staff competitively while maintaining margin
Wrap Rate Benchmarks	GSA-published rates, DCAA audits, industry surveys	Overhead, G&A, and fringe — your wrap rate vs. competitors' determines structural price advantage
Subcontractor Pricing	Negotiated quotes, GSA schedules, prior subcontract agreements	Sub pricing often represents 30–60% of total contract value on complex programs
Award Fee Potential	Prior contract incentive structures, agency contracting patterns	Affects total contract ceiling — should be modeled optimistically but bid conservatively
Option Year Escalation	Bureau of Labor Statistics Employment Cost Index (ECI)	Multi-year escalation assumptions can create significant pricing advantages or traps

Cost Realism and Price Reasonableness

For cost-type contracts, agencies evaluate cost realism — whether your proposed costs are realistic for the work you are proposing to do. An unrealistically low cost proposal can be evaluated as more expensive than a higher bid if the evaluators believe you will need modifications to cover underestimated costs.

For fixed-price contracts, agencies evaluate price reasonableness — whether your price is consistent with market rates for similar work. Know which contract type you are bidding and calibrate your pricing strategy accordingly.

Margin Management: Protecting Your Bottom Line

Winning a contract at unsustainable margins is not a victory — it is a slow-motion loss. Every firm has a margin floor below which work becomes destructive to long-term health. Set that floor before you begin PTW analysis, and treat it as non-negotiable.

- **Strategic floor:** Below this margin, the contract does not generate enough return to justify the management burden.
- **Tactical floor:** Below this margin, the firm may pursue the work only if it provides strategic positioning or past performance critical to a larger, more profitable future pursuit.
- **No-bid floor:** Below this margin, no strategic rationale justifies the work. Walk away.

***Pro-Tip:** Build your Price-to-Win model at least 90 days before RFP release — pricing decisions made under proposal pressure in the last 72 hours before submission are almost always wrong, and the margin you give away in a panicked final price review is profit you will never get back.*

Advanced Pricing Tactics

The Unbalanced Bid Strategy

In multi-year contracts, some firms strategically shift cost to option years where the government is more likely to exercise. This is legal when disclosed and structured properly, but it requires a deep understanding of the government's budgeting patterns and a strong relationship with the financial staff.

Most Efficient Organization (MEO) Awareness

On contracts that were previously performed in-house by government employees, you are competing against the government's own internal cost estimate — the Most Efficient Organization (MEO). Federal agencies use this as a price reasonableness benchmark. Know this number and price accordingly.

Using GSA Schedule Rates Strategically

If you hold a GSA Schedule contract, your published rates become a public benchmark. Competitors will use your GSA rates to model your pricing floor. Keep your GSA rates current, realistic, and strategically positioned relative to the market. Never let your GSA rates become a ceiling that constrains your ability to price competitively.

Common Pricing Mistakes That Kill Deals

- **Pricing to the ceiling, not to win:** Submitting at your internal cost model without checking whether that number is competitive in the market.
- **Ignoring wrap rate compression:** Competitors with lower overhead structures can underprice you on labor-heavy contracts while maintaining healthy margins. Know your cost structure.
- **Underpricing key personnel:** Submitting unrealistically low rates for named senior staff creates a cost realism risk — evaluators may question whether you can actually hire those people at that price.

- **Failing to model escalation:** Multi-year contracts with no cost escalation built in will erode your margins as labor costs rise with inflation.
- **Pricing the incumbent out of the market:** Aggressive underpricing can win you the contract and then bankrupt you on performance. The goal is a price you can actually deliver at.

CHAPTER 10

Post-Award & Lessons Learned: Turning Data into the Next Win

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

The contract award — win or lose — is not the end of the capture process; it is the beginning of the intelligence cycle for the next one, and the firms that harvest and act on post-award data consistently improve their win rates while competitors repeat their mistakes.

When You Win: Protecting the Asset

Winning a contract is worth nothing if you lose it on performance. The moment a contract is awarded, the recompile clock starts ticking. Every deliverable you miss, every customer complaint you ignore, every key person you lose is a deposit into your competitor's win strategy three years from now.

Contract performance is capture. Treat it that way.

- **Transition Execution:** Execute your transition plan with military precision. The first 90 days set the customer's performance expectation for the entire contract period.
- **Customer Relationship Continuity:** The BD team that won the contract should maintain active involvement during performance — not hand off the relationship to a program manager who has never met the customer.
- **Past Performance Documentation:** Proactively request Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System (CPARS) evaluations. A strong CPARS rating is your most powerful proposal asset for the next competition.
- **Scope Expansion Strategy:** Every task order, modification, and option exercise is a chance to deepen the relationship and expand revenue without a new competition.

When You Lose: The Debrief Is Mandatory

You are legally entitled to a debrief from the contracting agency after any competitive award. Demand it. A debrief is not a consolation prize — it is a strategic intelligence event that tells you exactly how the evaluators scored your proposal relative to the winner.

What to Ask in a Debrief

- What were your proposal's specific strengths by evaluation factor?
- What were your proposal's specific weaknesses or deficiencies by evaluation factor?

- How did the awardee's price compare to your proposed price?
- Were there any areas where your technical approach was evaluated as not meeting requirements?
- What was the evaluation methodology and weighting across factors?

The Post-Award Review Process

Within 30 days of any award decision — win or lose — BSI recommends conducting a formal post-award review with the capture team and BD leadership. This is not a blame session. It is a structured retrospective designed to extract actionable lessons from real competition data.

Review Category	Key Questions	Output
Capture Strategy Assessment	Did our intelligence accurately predict the customer's priorities? Where were we wrong?	Updated customer profile; revised intelligence collection plan
Competitive Intelligence Review	Did we accurately profile the winning team's approach and price? What did we miss?	Improved competitor database; refined PTW model
Proposal Quality Review	Which sections scored highest and lowest? Did our win themes land with evaluators?	Volume-by-volume quality improvement plan
Process Review	Where did the capture or proposal process break down? What caused delays or quality issues?	Updated playbook; process improvement actions
Team Performance Review	Which team members and partners added the most value? Where were gaps?	Updated teaming roster; training priorities identified
Pricing Review	Were we above, at, or below the winning price? By how much? Was PTW analysis accurate?	Refined PTW model; updated overhead and labor rate assumptions

Building Institutional Memory

The single biggest waste in federal business development is losing the same pursuit twice for the same reason. It happens constantly in firms that treat every proposal as a standalone event instead of as one data point in a long-running intelligence campaign.

Build a formal knowledge management system that captures every debrief, every customer contact log, every competitive assessment, and every proposal section that scored above 90%. These assets are your institutional memory — and they compound in value with every year you maintain them.

Key Performance Indicators for Capture Excellence

You cannot manage what you do not measure. Track these metrics across your full BD pipeline on a quarterly basis:

KPI	Definition	Target Benchmark
Win Rate (New Business)	$\text{Wins} \div \text{Total competitive bids submitted}$	> 35% for mature programs
Win Rate (Recompetes)	$\text{Recompete wins} \div \text{Total recompetes attempted}$	> 70% for healthy programs
Pipeline Coverage Ratio	$\text{Total pipeline TCV} \div \text{Annual revenue target}$	3x – 5x coverage
Bid & Proposal (B&P;) Ratio	$\text{B\&P; spend} \div \text{Total revenue}$	2% – 4% for steady-state programs
Revenue per BD FTE	$\text{Annual BD revenue generated} \div \text{BD headcount}$	Varies by market; track trends YoY
Average Capture Cycle Time	Months from opportunity ID to proposal submission	12–18 months for large bids
Proposal Debrief Rate	$\text{Debriefs requested} \div \text{Total losses}$	> 90% (always request the debrief)
PTW Accuracy	$(\text{PTW estimate} - \text{Winning price} \div \text{Winning price}) \times 100$	< 10% variance target

The Continuous Improvement Cycle

The best capture organizations do not just get better at individual deals — they build systems that make the organization smarter over time. After every award cycle, ask four questions:

- **What worked?** Document it, codify it, train to it.
- **What failed?** Diagnose the root cause, not the symptom.
- **What did we learn about the customer?** Update every profile and relationship map.
- **What do we need to do differently starting tomorrow?** Assign owners and deadlines.

A Final Word on the Federal Marketplace

The federal market rewards patience, preparation, and persistence above almost everything else. The firms that build sustainable, high-win-rate BD programs are not necessarily the most technically gifted or the most experienced. They are the most disciplined. They show up early, stay engaged, invest in relationships, and make decisions based on data rather than hope.

That discipline is what Bradford Starke, Inc. is built to develop in every consultant and every client we serve. The frameworks in this guide are not theoretical — they are the product of real campaigns, real wins, and hard-earned lessons from the field. Use them. Refine them. Make them yours.

Now go win something.

Pro-Tip: *The most powerful thing you can do for your BD pipeline right now is schedule 10 customer meetings in the next 60 days with agencies you want to work for in the next 24 months — every win you will celebrate two years from now starts with a conversation you have today.*

APPENDIX A

Capture Plan Template

BLUF — Bottom Line Up Front

A Capture Plan is a living document — start it early, update it constantly, and use it to drive every team decision. This template reflects BSI's standard capture plan structure for pursuits above \$5 million.

Section 1: Opportunity Overview

- Opportunity Name: _____
- Agency / Program Office: _____
- Contract Vehicle: _____
- Estimated Contract Value: _____
- Period of Performance: _____
- Anticipated RFP Release Date: _____
- Anticipated Award Date: _____
- NAICS Code: _____
- Set-Aside Status: _____
- Incumbent Contractor: _____

Section 2: Customer Intelligence Summary

- Primary Decision Maker (Name / Title): _____
- Contracting Officer (Name / Title): _____
- Technical Point of Contact: _____
- Customer Mission Priority: _____
- Known Pain Points / Requirements Gaps: _____
- Budget Status (Funded / Unfunded / Partial): _____
- Customer Relationship Status (Cold / Warm / Engaged / Partner):

Section 3: Competitive Assessment

- Likely Competitors (List Top 3): 1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____
- Incumbent Strengths: _____

- Incumbent Vulnerabilities: _____
- Your Firm Key Advantages: _____
- Ghost Proposal Summary (Incumbent): _____

Section 4: Win Strategy

- Win Theme 1: _____
- Win Theme 2: _____
- Win Theme 3: _____
- Primary Discriminator: _____
- Solution Concept Summary: _____

Section 5: Team Structure

- Prime Contractor: _____
- Subcontractor 1 / Role / Work Share %: _____
- Subcontractor 2 / Role / Work Share %: _____
- Small Business Designation(s) on Team: _____
- Teaming Agreement Status: _____

Section 6: Pricing Strategy

- Estimated Price-to-Win Target: _____
- Internal Cost Estimate: _____
- Target Margin: _____
- Key Pricing Risks: _____

Section 7: Bid/No-Bid Score

- BSI Bid/No-Bid Score (out of 50): _____ / 50
- Recommendation: Bid / No-Bid / Conditional Bid
- Approved By: _____
- Approval Date: _____

APPENDIX B

Glossary of Federal Acquisition Terms

Every industry has its own language. Federal contracting has more jargon than most. This glossary defines the terms you will encounter in capture campaigns, proposals, and contract negotiations. Know them cold — using the right vocabulary in customer conversations signals competence before you have proven anything.

B&P; (Bid and Proposal) Costs

The internal costs your firm incurs to prepare a proposal. These are recoverable on cost-type government contracts as an indirect cost, subject to FAR Part 31 limits.

BAFO (Best and Final Offer)

The final price and/or technical offer submitted during a negotiated procurement after the agency has conducted discussions with offerors. Not all procurements include a BAFO round.

CDRL (Contract Data Requirements List)

A list of deliverables — reports, plans, data items — the contractor is required to produce and submit to the government. Failing to deliver on CDRLs is a fast track to a poor CPARS rating.

CO (Contracting Officer)

The government official with legal authority to enter into, administer, and terminate contracts. The CO is the only person who can legally obligate government funds. Everything flows through them.

COTR / COR (Contracting Officer's Technical Representative)

The government employee who monitors contractor performance on a day-to-day basis. This is your primary working-level relationship — keep it strong.

CPARS (Contractor Performance Assessment Reporting System)

The government's official system for rating contractor performance. Ratings range from Exceptional to Unsatisfactory and are a major factor in proposal evaluations.

DFARS (Defense Federal Acquisition Regulation Supplement)

The overlay of rules that governs all Department of Defense acquisitions on top of the FAR. Critical knowledge for any firm pursuing DoD business.

FAR (Federal Acquisition Regulation)

The Master Rulebook governing all federal procurement. 2,000+ pages of rules, definitions, and clauses that apply to every government purchase. Required reading for senior capture professionals.

FPR (Final Proposal Revision)

A written revision to an original proposal, submitted after the agency has conducted discussions or clarifications. Treat every FPR as a standalone evaluation opportunity.

GWAC (Governmentwide Acquisition Contract)

A pre-competed contract vehicle available to all federal agencies, managed by a designated agency. Holding a GWAC seat is a prerequisite for competing on task orders against that vehicle.

IDIQ (Indefinite Delivery / Indefinite Quantity)

A contract that provides for an indefinite quantity of supplies or services, ordered through task orders or delivery orders. The ceiling value is a maximum, not a guarantee.

LPTA (Lowest Price Technically Acceptable)

An evaluation methodology where the award goes to the lowest-priced offeror whose proposal meets minimum technical requirements. Price is everything; differentiation above the floor adds zero value.

NAICS (North American Industry Classification System)

The code system used to classify businesses by industry. Your NAICS codes determine which small business set-asides you are eligible for and how the government categorizes your work.

OTA (Other Transaction Authority)

A legal authority that allows certain agencies — primarily DoD and DHS — to enter into agreements for prototype projects outside the FAR. A powerful pathway for non-traditional contractors.

Past Performance

Your track record on prior contracts. Evaluated in virtually every federal competition above the simplified acquisition threshold. Protect it aggressively — a single Unsatisfactory CPARS rating can haunt you for years.

PTW (Price-to-Win)

The analytical process of estimating the highest price you can submit and still win a competition. Built from competitive intelligence, historical award data, and cost modeling.

RFI (Request for Information)

A market research tool issued by agencies before a solicitation. Not a procurement — but an intelligence goldmine. Always respond to RFIs for opportunities you are pursuing.

RFP (Request for Proposal)

The formal solicitation document that defines the government's requirements and invites competitive proposals. Section L contains instructions; Section M contains evaluation criteria. Read both before you write a word.

SAM.gov (System for Award Management)

The federal government's official contractor registration and solicitation posting system. Every company doing business with the federal government must be registered here. Every solicitation above the micro-purchase threshold must be posted here.

SOW / PWS / SOO (Statement of Work / Performance Work Statement / Statement of Objectives)

The section of a contract that defines what the contractor must do. The PWS is output-based (here is what we need achieved); the SOW is input-based (here is how we want you to do it); the SOO is the broadest — it defines outcomes and lets the contractor propose the approach.

Teaming Agreement

A pre-proposal legal instrument between a prime and a subcontractor committing to pursue an opportunity together. Not a subcontract — it establishes the intent to subcontract and defines the terms of that future relationship.

APPENDIX C

BSI Capture Readiness Checklist

Use this checklist 60 days before every anticipated RFP release. If you cannot check every box, you have work to do. Non-checked items are not excuses — they are action items with owners and deadlines.

Category	Readiness Item	Status
Customer Intelligence	We have met face-to-face with the Program Manager within the last 90 days	☐
Customer Intelligence	We know the customer's top three performance priorities for this contract	☐
Customer Intelligence	We have confirmed the requirement is funded in the current or next FY	☐
Customer Intelligence	We have reviewed the agency's Strategic Plan and Budget Justification	☐
Competitive Intel	We have identified the likely incumbent and three likely challengers	☐
Competitive Intel	We have completed a SWOT analysis on each key competitor	☐
Competitive Intel	We have completed a Ghost Proposal for the incumbent	☐
Competitive Intel	We have reviewed the incumbent's contract value and performance history	☐
Win Strategy	We have a documented win strategy with at least three true discriminators	☐
Win Strategy	Our win themes are tied to the customer's specific mission priorities	☐
Win Strategy	Our solution has been reviewed by a former federal customer or subject expert	☐
Win Strategy	We can articulate why we will beat the incumbent in one sentence	☐
Team Structure	Our prime/sub team structure is finalized and teaming agreements are signed	☐
Team Structure	All key personnel are identified, committed, and available on RFP day	☐
Team Structure	Small business requirements are addressed by the team composition	☐
Pricing	We have completed a Price-to-Win analysis based on current market data	☐
Pricing	Our proposed price yields a margin at or above our strategic floor	☐
Pricing	We have modeled option year escalation and wrap rate sensitivity	☐

Category	Readiness Item	Status
Proposal Readiness	Proposal volume leads are assigned and available	[]
Proposal Readiness	A compliance matrix has been built from the draft RFP or prior solicitation	[]
Proposal Readiness	Past performance references are selected, contacted, and prepared	[]
Proposal Readiness	Color review schedule is set and reviewers are confirmed	[]
Gate Approval	Bid/No-Bid score exceeds 38 and leadership has approved full pursuit	[]
Gate Approval	B&P; budget is allocated and tracked against the proposal schedule	[]

Bradford Starke, Inc. | Strategy & Growth Division | Federal Consulting Practice

© 2025 Bradford Starke, Inc. All rights reserved. Proprietary & Confidential.